It was a week later that the Canadian premier dropped a bombshell on India when he told members of Canada's House of Commons, the equivalent of the Lok Sabha, that "Canadian security agencies have been actively pursuing credible allegations of a potential link between agents of the Government of India and the killing of a Canadian citizen, Hardeep Singh Nijjar". A ruler of a nation, especially one belonging to the powerful Group of 7 or G-7 nations, accusing India of being involved in an extra-judicial killing of a foreign citizen in a foreign country was unprecedented—that too, without providing evidence. An angry India described Trudeau's allegations as "absurd" and, in turn, charged Canada with becoming "a safe haven for terrorists, extremists and organised crime". The exchange sparked off a diplomatic firestorm that threatens to grievously gut relations between the two nations.

WHERE'S THE SMOKING GUN ?

In the following days, both countries indulged in tit-for-tat punitive actions against each other. Canada took the first step of expelling an Indian diplomat, Pavan Kumar Rai, a Punjab-cadre IPS officer, posted in Ottawa. India followed it up by expelling a Canadian diplomat based in the country's High Commission in Delhi. Canada announced it was pausing ongoing negotiations for an Early Progress Trade Agreement with India; New Delhi retaliated by suspending visa services, including e-visas, in Canada. It also asked Ottawa to trim the number of diplomats posted in India, around 90, to India's 30 in Canada. India faced a setback when a *New York Times* report revealed that after Sikh extremist Nijjar was killed in a shootout in Surrey in Canada, US intelligence officials had shared information with Ottawa that helped it conclude India was involved. Quoting unnamed US officials, the report stated that it was their Canadian counterparts who finally unearthed the "smoking gun", gathering intelligence, including intercepted communication or SIGINT (signals intelligence) of Indian diplomats in Canada, indicating New Delhi's possible involvement.

Coming after a successful execution of its G20 presidency, the allegations had geopolitical implications that could undo India's enhanced global stature and reputation. Canada is part of the Five Eyes alliance, which includes the US, UK, Australia and New Zealand, countries whose intelligence agencies share information with each other routinely. US officials revealed that President Joe Biden had already taken up the Nijjar killing issue with PM Modi during his bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the G20

THE TEETH OF THE TIGER

Security agencies believe that Nijjar, as head of the KTF, created a pro-Khalistani network in Canada, allegedly hiring gangsters to carry out targeted killings and organising armed training camps

On June 18, two shooters wearing hoodies waylaid a grey pickup truck outside a gurdwara in Surrey, a town on the western coast of Canada, pumped some 35 rounds into the occupant and escaped. Ordinarily, this would have passed off as a stray gangland killing, but the victim here was Hardeep Singh Nijjar, 45, the head of the banned militant outfit, Khalistan Tiger Force (KTF), and a wanted terrorist in India with a bounty of Rs 10 lakh on his head. The Indian government's list of charges against Nijjar was long—in the past 15 years, he had allegedly ordered several targeted killings in Punjab, collaborated with Pakistan's ISI, used Khalistani militants to smuggle arms into India, run an extortion racket with other Punjab-based gangsters and promoted anti-India sentiments among Sikhs in Canada as well as India.

Born in 1977 in a village near Jalandhar, Nijjar migrated to Canada as a 20-year-old, allegedly on a fake passport and a fake name, Ravi Sharma. A plumber by trade, he was suspected to have been close to the slain militant and Khalistan Commando Force (KCF) commander, Gurdeep Singh a.k.a. Deepa Heran Wala. Nijjar's asylum papers filed before the Canadian authorities in 1998 claim he was arrested in 1995 by the Punjab Police and "tortured". His claims were repeatedly rejected, but by 2001, possibly with the help of the Sikh diaspora, he acquired Canadian citizenship.

Nijjar seems to have flown under the radar for the next few years, though there are reports of his meeting like-minded